First News

18 Mar 2026

Employing Intelligent investing, a disciplined, long-term approach to wealth creation based on fundamental analysis, risk management, and emotional control.

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Global, Regional Markets

U.S. stocks closed higher , shrugging off rising geopolitical tensions as oil prices continued to climb on the Iran conflict. Gains in tech & energy shares supported the broader market, even as crude hovered above $100 a barrel, keeping inflation risks in focus for investors.

Gold edged higher while the dollar and U.S. Treasury yields slipped, signaling a mild defensive tone in markets.

- Investors rotated toward safe-haven assets as uncertainty around global growth and geopolitics lingered.

Brent Crude: Settled at $103.42 per barrel (+3.2%). WTI Crude: Settled at $96.21 per barrel (+2.9%).
0- Monthly Gain: Brent has climbed nearly 43% month-to-date.

China has begun restricting offshore-incorporated "red-chip" firms from pursuing IPOs in Hong Kong.

- This move aims to tighten oversight on companies that are registered in offshore hubs like the Cayman Islands but hold their primary assets and operations within mainland China
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DA MARKET SECURITIES

Asia-Pacific

	3/17/2026	3/18/2026	%Chg
Dow Jones	46,946	46,993	0.10%
S&P 500	6,699	6,716	0.25%
NASDAQ	22,374	22,480	0.47%
PCOMP	6,113.58	6,026.01	-1.43%
NKY	54,081.84	54,435.67	0.65%
SHCOMP	4084.79	4049.91	-0.85%
HSI	25,834.02	25,868.54	0.13%
KOSPI	5697.19	5849.44	2.67%
SENSEX	75,502.85	76,070.84	0.75%
TWSE	33,343	33,837	1.48%
ASX200	8588.4	8617.4	0.34%
BURSAKLCI	1696.56	1710.99	0.85%
JCI	7022.29	7106.84	1.20%
STI	4868.69	4935.97	1.38%
SET	933.25	953.66	2.19%
VNINDEX	1693.21	1710.29	1.01%

DA MARKET SECURITIES

Commodities - Metals & Agriculture

	3/17/2026	3/18/2026	%Chg
WTI Crude	95.74	94.76	-1.02%
Brent Crude	102.56	102.36	-0.20%
Gold (Comex)	5010.7	5007.9	-0.06%
Silver (Comex)	80.65	79.2	-1.80%
Platinum Spot	2111.11	2142.95	1.51%
Copper (Comex)	582.8	576.1	-1.15%
Nickel	7.8721	7.7867	-1.08%
Nickel Ore Phl 1.5%	80	65	-18.75%
Nickel Ore Phl 1.8%	94.5	79.5	-15.87%
Coal	135	134.75	-0.19%
Corn	457.75	455.5	-0.49%
Wheat	604.5	591	-2.23%
Cocoa	3418	3349	-2.02%
Sugar	14.19	14.45	1.83%

Strategy

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Philippines

Economist and former NEDA chief Winnie Monsod posed an alternative to suspending excise tax on fuel products: taxing the 50 wealthiest billionaires in the country.

- Monsod warned that suspending excise taxes would leave the government short on funds for its aid programs, noting that the same failed in 2022 when fuel prices also spiked.
- She said this would later on hurt, rather than help, the bottom half of Filipinos. The economics professor added that the "wealth tax" during crises would allow the country's richest to "pay back a little bit" to the Filipino people.

Flights booked between April 1 and 15, 2026, will be costlier by as much as P6,200, as airlines were allowed to increase fuel surcharge to Level 8.

- **F**uel surcharge at Level 8 Domestic flights: P253 to P787 International flights: P835.05 to P6,208.98

MARCOS ORDERS REDUCTION OF AIRLINE, AIRFARE COSTS

- **P**resident Bongbong Marcos said the Civil Aviation Authority of the Philippines will reduce passenger service charges, landing fees, and parking fees to help bring down airfare costs. The Civil Aeronautics Board will also shorten the review period for fuel surcharge rates

Ferdinand “Perry” Ferrer, President of the Philippine Chamber of Commerce and Industry, says small businesses are preparing for rising material and logistics costs amid higher fuel prices.

- Support is needed for the 1.2 million MSMEs before these costs reach consumers.

Finance Secretary Frederick Go recently stated that while there are no immediate plans to revise the Philippines' 2026 GDP growth target, the government is closely monitoring global oil prices following recent Middle East conflicts.

- **F**inance Secretary Frederick D. Go says Philippines to Buy 2M Barrels of Oil From Global Market
- **F**rederick Go is a Filipino business executive and government official, Special Assistant to the President for Investment and Economic Affairs (2024–2025) under President Marcos. A former property tycoon, he led Robinsons Land Corporation as President and CEO for over 30 years

DA MARKET SECURITIES

Philippines

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6026 +19.46 pts., +0.32%

Range 6,014.52 - 6,073.10

Breadth 92 (+) 95 (-) 53 (unch)

Block Php1.83B **Volume** 1.06B **Value** Php7.43B

Share buyback sm ict opm spmh meg

52wk H: opm
52wk L: ara bhi dito land

Overbought – acr dhi
Oversold – land lbc pmpc gtcap t ech vlc pha bpi tugs ali

Active	Value
ICT	1140
BPI	497
JFC	370
BDO	270
ALI	269
PLUS	156
MBT	253
SMPH	169
SM	167

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DA MARKET SECURITIES

Foreign Trade

NFB(S)	$9.415mn
Total FB Feb	$10.696mn
YTD NFB	$236.516mn

FB	3,563,059,539.12
FS	4,126,277,268.29
NFB(S)	563,217,729.17
TOTAL	7,689,336,807.41

Foreign Funds Bought
aub ew secb dhi mwc mynld sgp ac cosco hi jgs ltg areit meg mrc rcr rlc dito glo ceb ict mac bloom plus apx

Foreign Funds Sold
bdo bpi cbc mbt pnb acen alter ap fgen mer pcor scc spnec cnpf dnl emi fb gsmi monde rfm urc aev agi dmc gtcap sm smc ali creit dd mreit smph tel apl cnvrg web pgold rrhi ssi wlcon at nikl ogp px

SmartWatch Tuesday 3/17/26
ICT AP WEB MRC DMC RCR BDO BPI AC JGS MYNLD MWC AC AP STI COSCO NEG MAC NIKL AP

10yr Bond	3/17/2026	3/18/2...	%Chg
PHL	6.712	6.728	0.24%
US	4.235	4.201	-0.80%

Currency Pair	3/17/2...	3/18/2...	%Chg
USD-JPY	159.29	159.11	0.64%
USD-PHP	59.898	59.808	0.06%
USD-CNY	6.8917	6.8851	0.24%
EUR-USD	1.1492	1.1535	-0.35%

NEWS, ANALYSIS , INVESTING INSIGHT

ACR 0.91

- Shares of Alcantara-led Alsons Consolidated Resources Inc. (ACR) surged 47% on Tuesday, ranking as the second biggest gainer on the local bourse as investors positioned for exposure to one of Southeast Asia’s largest untapped copper-gold deposit.

SMC 69.00

- San Miguel Sees Growth Despite Geopolitical Risks Shares of San Miguel Corporation rose as much as 1.8% after the conglomerate reported 2025 net income largely in line with market expectations, signaling resilience despite ongoing geopolitical uncertainties.

SM 633

- **SM Chair Tessie Sy-Coson warns that a weak peso will drive up consumer prices, forcing the central bank to raise rates.**
    - Growth to slow & consumer market to soften, she's confident in the resilience of banks, unconcerned by bad debt. She views war as a temporary setback.
- **SM Vice Chair Tessie Sy-Coson expects BSP to raise interest rates as early as April due to rising oil prices, with consumer spending expected to soften toward essentials**
    - Operating expenses to rise, SM optimistic that this is a temporary setback for the Philippine economy

DHI 6.03

- Bilyonaryos Henry “Big Boy” Sy Jr. of SM Investments Corp. and Isidro “Sid” Consunji of DMCI Holdings Inc. are among the key new names in the sweeping boardroom overhaul at Dominion Holdings Inc., raising speculation over a possible SM-DMCI alliance after Monte Sur Equity Holdings Inc. took control.

Philippine Property stocks fall on a possible BSP rate hike!

JFC 186.20

- **JFC is exploring a US exchange listing for its international arm; digital wallet Maya is evaluating a US IPO for higher fintech valuations and liquidity.**

NEWS, ANALYSIS , INVESTING INSIGHT

MER 602.00

- Meralco PowerGen CEO Rubio says Philippine plants may use more coal to offset high fuel prices caused war.
- While coal currently supplements expensive LNG, Meralco is accelerating renewable investments to lower costs: 3,500 MW solar capacity. 4,700 MW battery storage.

PSE 203.00

- **PSE President & CEO Monzon says PSE focused on more listings & boosting market liquidity.**
    - GCash IPO on track Philippines nearing start of short-selling
    - Big share sales by miner & solar firm;
    - Pushing to list more small businesses;
    - mega IPOs in pipeline (two big ones);

ICTSI 704.00

- Pier 14 NorthPort Upgrade Ahead of Schedule; $740M 2026 Capex FY2025 profits reached $1.05 billion (+23%).
- Ahead-of-schedule execution and globally diversified portfolio make ICTSI a relative safe haven amid geopolitical stress.

NEWS, ANALYSIS , INVESTING INSIGHT

DMC 9.61

- DMCI Holdings is lifting its capital expenditure budget to P24.6 billion in 2026, up 11% from P22.2 billion in 2025. The bulk — P15.5 billion or 65% — goes to property arm DMCI Homes, while DMCI Power gets P3.3 billion for 44 MW of new capacity in Palawan, Occidental Mindoro, and Calapan.
- Full-year 2025 net income fell 20% to P15.1 billion, with Semirara's contribution down sharply on softer energy prices, while the cement unit Concreat posted a P1.9 billion net loss.
- **Analysis:** The capex ramp signals management's confidence in residential demand recovery and off-grid power expansion. However, the earnings backdrop remains soft — Semirara pressure and Concreat's ongoing losses are headwinds that won't clear quickly. The P15.5B for DMCI Homes is actually lower than the P17.9B allocated in 2025, suggesting a more disciplined, pace-and-price approach rather than outright expansion. Shares fell 1.94% to P9.61 on Tuesday.
- **Stance: MONITOR.** No clear near-term catalyst. Earnings recovery contingent on coal/power price normalization and cement turnaround. Watch for Q1 2026 guidance.

SGP 19.00

- **NGCP — Proposes P23.9B Batangas-Mindoro Subsea Cable**
- The National Grid Corp. of the Philippines is proposing a 500-kV submarine cable crossing the Verde Island Passage from Lobo, Batangas to Calapan City, Oriental Mindoro — a 28.5-kilometer link targeting completion by January 2028. The subsea cable forms Stage 1 of the broader P90.6-billion Batangas-Mindoro Interconnection and Backbone Project (BMIBP), which the Department of Energy has certified as a project of national significance.
- **Analysis:** NGCP is not listed, so there is no direct equity play here. However, this is significant for the broader energy sector: it unlocks Mindoro's massive offshore wind potential (estimated 28 GW), reduces reliance on diesel generation in an isolated grid, and supports future renewable energy capacity. Indirectly positive for listed energy developers with Mindoro exposure or renewable pipelines. Meralco (MER) and MGEN also benefit as offtakers from a more reliable grid backbone.
- **Stance: Sector positive. No direct PSE play on NGCP.**

NEWS, ANALYSIS , INVESTING INSIGHT

PLUS 17.30

- **DigiPlus posted full-year revenue growth of 12% to P84.2 billion, but net income held flat at P12.6 billion as a strong first half was offset by the Q3 slowdown following the mandated delinking of e-wallets from licensed online gaming platforms.**
- Q4 net income fell 36% year-on-year to P2.5 billion; however, it recovered 43% quarter-on-quarter from Q3 as the company recalibrated operations and tightened costs.
- DigiPlus ended the year with P23.4 billion in cash and minimal debt of P745.8 million, and declared P3.8 billion in dividends.
- **Analysis:** The flat net income headline belies a tale of two halves. The recovery in Q4 profitability (QoQ basis) is encouraging and suggests the regulatory shock is being absorbed. The P12B investment in International Entertainment Corp. convertible notes — potentially yielding a 53.89% stake and an offline gaming foothold — is strategically bold but adds execution risk and capital deployment uncertainty. Shares fell 3.89% to P17.30 on Tuesday.
- **Stance: MONITOR.** The Q4 recovery and clean balance sheet are positives. Watch for Q1 2026 results to confirm whether the e-wallet re-adjustment is fully behind them. The land-based casino bet is long-dated. For yield-oriented investors, the dividend consistency is worth noting.

APX 15.20

- **Apex Mining reported a 77% jump in consolidated net income to P7.66 billion for 2025, driven by gold and silver price strength. Revenue rose 41% to P21.34 billion. Average realized gold price surged 45% to $3,531/oz, more than offsetting a 4% dip in volume. Silver volume also rose 4% while prices jumped 50%.**
- The company doubled its cash dividend payout rate to 20% of consolidated net income from the previous 10%.
- **Analysis:** This is a strong earnings print. The doubling of the dividend payout ratio is a direct reward to shareholders and a confidence signal from management. The key question going forward is price sustainability — gold has been running on geopolitical and macro tailwinds. Volume growth remains constrained by grade dilution. That said, with reserves at Maco Mine sufficient until 2034 and the Sangilo mine contributing, the production base is solid.
- **Stance:** ACCUMULATE on pullbacks. Leverage to gold prices remains high. At current gold levels above $3,000/oz, earnings visibility is strong. The dividend uplift adds yield support.

NEWS, ANALYSIS , INVESTING INSIGHT

MER 602.00

- **MGEN/Meralco (MER) — Considers Minority Stake in Semirara Partnership**
- Meralco PowerGen Corp. (MGEN) confirmed it is exploring a minority stake in a potential partnership with Semirara Mining and Power Corp. (SMPC) to participate in the upcoming auction for the country's largest coal mining concession. MGEN's CEO noted the company is conducting due diligence on coal composition and suitability for its thermal plants.
- The DOE has launched the 2026 Philippine Conventional Energy Contracting Program bid round, with 10 Semirara blocks covering 10,000 hectares on offer. Estimated reserves stand at 160 million metric tons. Winners are expected to be announced by May.
- **Analysis:** This is strategically significant. MGEN's fuel security rationale is sound — securing upstream coal supply for its large coal-fired fleet is a logical vertical integration move. A minority position (not full operator) reduces execution risk while still providing supply certainty.
- For SCC (Semirara), this development is a stabilizer: a MGEN partnership effectively means the incumbent retains operational control while gaining a deep-pocketed co-bidder. For MER, the read-through is long-term fuel cost management and earnings visibility for MGEN.

DNL 3.55

- D**&L Industries (DNL) — Limited Impact from Biofuel Suspension**
- **D**&L Industries stated that the proposed temporary suspension of biofuel blending mandates is not expected to have a material impact. The company noted the current price differential between biodiesel-blended and pure diesel is approximately 1.33%, well below the 5% threshold that would trigger any suspension. D&L's biodiesel unit, Chemrez Technologies, retains flexibility to redirect production to higher-value oleochemical exports should domestic biodiesel demand temporarily soften.
- **Analysis:** This is a proactive investor relations move by management — getting ahead of what could have been a market concern. The reassurance is credible given the current differential data. The operational flexibility to redirect to oleochemical exports limits downside. The long-term biofuels policy direction remains intact under the Biofuels Act.
- **Stance: NEUTRAL.** The news removes a minor overhang but adds no new positive catalyst. DNL remains a steady, low-volatility industrial play.

NEWS, ANALYSIS , INVESTING INSIGHT

CREIT 3.25

- **CREIT — Retains PRS Aa+ Rating, Stable Outlook**
- Citicore Energy REIT Corp. sustained its PRS Aa+ credit rating with a stable outlook from PhilRatings, covering both the issuer rating and its outstanding P4.5 billion ASEAN Green Bonds. The rating reflects CREIT's fully occupied green asset portfolio, strong margins, reputable shareholders, and sound financial position.
- Analysis: For a REIT, credit rating maintenance is a critical input to dividend sustainability and bond refinancing capacity. The stable outlook means no rating action is expected in the next 12 months. CREIT's 100% occupancy by solar operators provides highly visible, cycle-resilient income. This is a quiet positive — no new news, but a reassuring reaffirmation for income-focused investors.
- Stance: ACCUMULATE for yield investors. CREIT is one of the cleanest REIT stories on the PSE — pure RE exposure, tight occupancy, and a credible growth pipeline tied to Citicore RE Corp.'s 5GW target.

ATI 29.00

- M**aharlika Investment Corp. / ATI — Completes Stake Acquisition in Asian Terminals**
- Maharlika Investment Corporation completed the crossing and settlement of - Asian Terminals Inc. (ATI) shares on March 17, 2026, following a tender offer.
- Maharlika has formally become a shareholder of ATI, acquiring shares from Seawood Resources, Kayak Holdings, Asiasec Equities, and public shareholders who tendered. MIC ultimately holds approximately 11.2% of ATI at a deal value of around P8 billion, with an offer price of P36 per share. The deal includes up to one board seat for the government.
- A**nalysis:** The deal is now closed — a milestone for MIC as the Philippines' first sovereign wealth fund cements its first major infrastructure investment. For ATI (now delisted), this means government-aligned capital and board visibility at one of the country's most critical port operators. The broader read-through is that MIC is an active market participant, and future investments in listed companies (or their delisting) bear watching — particularly for companies in logistics, energy, and digital infrastructure that align with MIC's stated sectors.